

Homeowner Hidden Costs Anxiety — Action Checklist

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CALCULATE TOTAL OWNERSHIP COSTS

- ☐ **Calculate Total Ownership Costs:** Add property taxes, insurance premiums, utilities, maintenance reserves, landscaping, and HOA fees to your mortgage payment to see the full \$21,000+ annual cost of homeownership.
- ☐ **Calculate Total Ownership Costs:** Set aside 1-2% of your home's purchase price each year in a dedicated maintenance fund to cover routine repairs, appliance replacements, and system failures without financial strain.
- ☐ **Calculate Total Ownership Costs:** Research your specific state's property tax rates and your home's insurance requirements before closing to build an accurate monthly budget that includes all non-mortgage costs.
- ☐ **Calculate Total Ownership Costs:** Factor in PMI costs if your down payment was under 20% and budget \$100-\$300 monthly until you reach 20% equity to avoid payment surprises after closing.

ASSESS HOME CONDITION

- ☐ **Assess Home Condition:** Request all home maintenance records, appliance age documentation, and contractor invoices from the previous owners to understand which systems may need replacement soon after move-in.
- ☐ **Assess Home Condition:** Hire a specialized inspector beyond the standard home inspection to evaluate the roof's remaining lifespan, HVAC system age, and plumbing infrastructure for hidden issues behind walls.
- ☐ **Assess Home Condition:** Create a priority list of aging systems based on typical lifespans—water heaters last 8-15 years, dishwashers 6-10 years, roofs 15-25 years for asphalt—to anticipate replacement costs.
- ☐ **Assess Home Condition:** Document the age and condition of all major appliances at move-in so you can build a realistic replacement timeline and save incrementally for these inevitable expenses.

BUILD MAINTENANCE PLAN

- ☐ **Build Maintenance Plan:** Schedule annual HVAC maintenance and preventive inspections to extend system lifespan and catch minor issues before they become expensive emergency repairs in year one.

 - ☐ **Build Maintenance Plan:** Create a seasonal maintenance calendar that includes gutter cleaning, landscaping care, and exterior inspections to protect your home's structure and prevent costly water damage.

 - ☐ **Build Maintenance Plan:** Establish relationships with trusted local contractors for plumbing, electrical, and general repairs before you need them so emergency calls go to professionals you already know.

 - ☐ **Build Maintenance Plan:** Review your insurance coverage annually and compare rates as your home ages to ensure you are paying appropriate premiums for your property's current condition and risk profile.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.